METRIC BEHAVIOR DIAGNOSTIC

PURPOSE

Examine what a metric measures, what behavior it encourages, and whether improvement in the number actually represents improvement in the system.

WHAT IT IS

A structured way to examine the relationship between a metric, the behaviors it creates, and the decisions it supports.

WHAT IT IS NOT

A KPI scorecard, metric-selection formula, dashboard standard, or grading system.

DIAGNOSTIC LENS

A. START WITH THE METRIC

Before deciding whether a metric is useful, establish what it was intended to do and what it actually measures.

What metric are we examining?

How is it calculated? What is included, excluded, counted, averaged, classified, or otherwise transformed?

01 INTENT

What decision or behavior was this metric meant to support?

Why does this metric exist? What were we hoping to understand, influence, detect, or improve?

02 MEASURE

What does the metric actually measure?

Separate the metric's stated purpose from the observable thing being counted.

03 INCENTIVE

What does improving the number encourage people to do?

What behavior does the measurement system reward, discourage, prioritize, or make visible?

04 RESPONSE

What do people actually do because this metric exists?

Look for changes in prioritization, workflow, reporting, escalation, classification, or decision-making.

05 TRADE-OFF

What can improve here while something else gets worse?

Consider quality, service, risk, cost, workload, timeliness, learning, and downstream performance.

06 GAMING

How could someone improve the metric without improving the system?

Gaming does not require malicious intent. People adapt to the systems around them. Consider classification, timing, exclusions, batching, deferral, selective reporting, or shifting work.

OBSERVATIONS / EVIDENCE

B. TEST THE SIGNAL

A metric can improve while the system it represents stays the same—or gets worse.

07 SIGNAL — IF THIS METRIC IMPROVES, WHAT DO WE ACTUALLY KNOW?

Separate the conclusion that movement in the metric legitimately supports from conclusions the metric cannot establish.

WHAT THE SIGNAL SUPPORTS

What can we legitimately infer from movement in this metric?

WHAT THE SIGNAL DOES NOT ESTABLISH

What remains unknown, indirect, or unsupported?

08 DECISION — WHAT SHOULD THIS METRIC CAUSE SOMEONE TO DECIDE OR DO?

Who should act? What decision does the metric inform? What happens when it moves—and what happens when it doesn't?

C. TRACE THE SYSTEM

Follow the metric beyond the number. Trace what it signals, what people do in response, and what happens in the actual system.

METRIC

What number are we watching?

SIGNAL

What can we legitimately infer from it?

BEHAVIOR

What behavior does it encourage or produce?

OUTCOME

What happens in the actual system?

IF THIS METRIC IMPROVED SIGNIFICANTLY TOMORROW, WHAT WOULD WE ACTUALLY KNOW?

OPEN LAB NOTE: Metrics are part of the system they measure. Once a measure becomes visible, consequential, or connected to performance, people adapt to it. That does not make metrics bad. It means metric design should consider not only what gets measured, but what happens because it is measured.

Use it. Challenge it. Change it. Make it better. Share what you learned.

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